

THE STUDY • UNC CHARLOTTE • UCF • RANDOMIZED TRIAL • 2016

# Does daily meditation lower stress in graduate students?

## A randomized trial with counseling students, and the role of emotional intelligence



Department of Counseling, University of North Carolina at Charlotte



Department of Counselor Education, University of Central Florida

# -25%

WITH DAILY SOS MEDITATION

vs.

# unchanged

WITH SKILLS-LAB COMPARISON

Masters-level counseling students who *practiced SOS meditation daily* for 6 weeks cut their perceived stress by about a quarter – the comparison group *didn't*.



### WHO

#### 60 graduate counseling students

Masters-level counseling students (88% female, mean age 24) in their first semester of a counselor-education program at a US southeastern university.



### WHAT

#### 6 weeks of weekly class + daily practice

Jyoti (SOS) meditation taught in weekly class with at-home daily practice. Compared to a psychoeducational communication-skills laboratory group.



### WE FOUND

#### Stress dropped for daily practitioners

Among students who meditated ≥10 min/day at home (n = 20), stress scores fell by 25% over 6 weeks. The comparison group stayed flat.



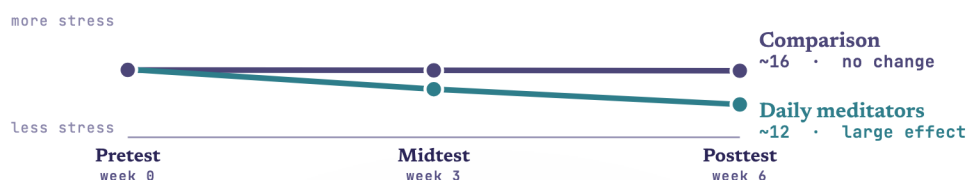
### AND

#### EI amplified the effect

Students with higher baseline emotional intelligence (EI) showed stronger stress reductions from meditation.

### PRIMARY OUTCOME

#### Perceived Stress over 6 weeks (PSS, 0–40)



↓ Within the daily-meditation group, the pre-to-post drop was large (Hedges  $g = 0.84$ ). In the comparison group it was essentially zero ( $g = 0.01$ ). Between-group medium effect at posttest ( $g = 0.57$ ).

### WHAT WE ALSO FOUND Emotional intelligence shaped the response – and adherence mattered.

#### ✓ STRONGER EFFECT FOR STUDENTS WHO:

Meditated ≥ 10 min/day at home

Had higher baseline emotional intelligence

🔴 HONEST CAVEAT: The full intention-to-treat sample (n = 60) did not show a significant group × time interaction ( $p = .14$ ). The effect emerged when restricted to **adherent daily practitioners** (n = 20).

→ SOS meditation was called *Jyoti* meditation when this trial was conducted. The practice is the same.

### HOW TO READ THIS

Randomized but unblinded. Primary headline finding is for adherent practitioners only (n = 20); intention-to-treat analysis (n = 60) did not reach significance. Single-semester, single-site sample of US graduate counseling students; 88% female. 6-week endpoint with no long-term follow-up.

### CITATION

Gutierrez D, Conley AH, Young M (2016). Examining the effects of Jyoti meditation on stress and the moderating role of emotional intelligence. *Counselor Education & Supervision* 55(2):109–122. doi:10.1002/ceas.12036.

